

76 Jeroboam I

The gifted rebel who was offered a lasting kingdom, then traded it for two golden calves.

Jeroboam son of Nebat was the first king of the northern kingdom of Israel. He began as a capable officer in Solomon's building works. A prophet told him God would give him ten tribes and, if he obeyed, a dynasty as secure as David's. The promise came true when the tribes broke from Rehoboam. But Jeroboam feared that worship in Jerusalem would turn his people's hearts, so he set up golden calves at Bethel and Dan. That choice shaped the north for two centuries: later kings walked in "the sins of Jeroboam the son of Nebat, who made Israel to sin."

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Yarovam</i> . The meaning is uncertain
Family	Son of Nebat of Zereda and Zeruah, a widow (1 Kings 11:26)
Rose as	Solomon's officer over the house of Joseph's labour
Reign	22 years over the north, c. 931–910 BC (1 Kings 14:20)
Key places	Egypt, Shechem, Penuel, Tirzah, Bethel, Dan
Key people	Solomon, Ahijah, Rehoboam, the man of God from Judah
New Testament	Not named

"Whereupon the king took counsel, and made two calves of gold, and said unto them, It is too much for you to go up to Jerusalem: behold thy gods, O Israel, which brought thee up out of the land of Egypt."

1 Kings 12:28, KJV

The life of Jeroboam I

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the house chronology. Scripture does not date the events before Solomon's death.

Under Solomon	● Rises through hard work Solomon sees the young man is industrious and puts him over the labour of the house of Joseph. <i>1 Kings 11:26-28</i>
Under Solomon	● The torn garment The prophet Ahijah tears his new garment into twelve pieces and gives Jeroboam ten, promising a lasting house if he obeys. <i>1 Kings 11:29-39</i>
Late in Solomon's reign	● Flees to Egypt Jeroboam lifts up his hand against the king. Solomon seeks to kill him, so he flees to Shishak until Solomon dies. <i>1 Kings 11:26-27, 40</i>
c. 931 BC	● Made king of Israel After Rehoboam's harsh answer, the northern tribes call Jeroboam to their assembly and make him king. <i>1 Kings 12:2-3, 20</i>
c. 931 BC <i>Year 1</i>	● Golden calves Fearing his people will turn back to David's house, he sets up calves at Bethel and Dan, with his own priests and feast. <i>1 Kings 12:25-33</i>
At Bethel	● The man of God A prophet from Judah cries out against the altar. Jeroboam's hand dries up and is healed, yet he does not turn. <i>1 Kings 13:1-6, 33-34</i>
Later	● His son falls sick His wife goes in disguise to Ahijah, who announces the end of Jeroboam's house. The boy dies. <i>1 Kings 14:1-18</i>
c. 910 BC <i>22nd year</i>	● Dies Defeated by Abijah of Judah, he never recovers. The LORD strikes him, and Nadab reigns after him. <i>1 Kings 14:19-20; 2 Chronicles 13:1-20</i>

Key activities

Kings treats the calves as the root sin of the northern kingdom. Almost every later northern king is measured against "the sins of Jeroboam."

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- 1 Worked hard for Solomon.** His energy and ability won him a senior post over the labourers of Ephraim and Manasseh. *1 Kings 11:28*

 - 2 Received a conditional promise.** God offered him "a sure house" like David's, if he would keep God's statutes and commandments. *1 Kings 11:37-38*

 - 3 Led the tribes' appeal.** He and the assembly asked Rehoboam to lighten the heavy service Solomon had imposed. *1 Kings 12:3-4*

 - 4 Built up his kingdom.** He fortified Shechem as his capital and also built Penuel across the Jordan. *1 Kings 12:25*

 - 5 Reasoned from fear.** He told himself that worship in Jerusalem would turn his people back to Rehoboam, and that they would kill him. *1 Kings 12:26-27*

 - 6 Made two golden calves.** He set one in Bethel and one in Dan, and the people went to worship before them. *1 Kings 12:28-30*

 - 7 Invented a religion.** He built shrines on high places, made priests from people who were not Levites, and set a feast in a month "which he had devised of his own heart." *1 Kings 12:31-33*

 - 8 Refused to turn back.** Even after the sign at Bethel, he kept appointing priests for the high places. This became the sin that cut off his house. *1 Kings 13:33-34*

 - 9 Sought a prophet in secret.** When his son fell ill, he sent his wife in disguise to Ahijah instead of going himself. *1 Kings 14:1-4*

 - 10 Fought Judah.** He waged war with Rehoboam and then Abijah, and was defeated in battle. *1 Kings 15:6-7; 2 Chronicles 13:3-20*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jeroboam.

Old Testament

1 Kings 11:26–14:20; 2 Chronicles 10–13	The main accounts of his life
1 Kings 15:29–30	Baasha destroys Jeroboam's house, as Ahijah said
1 Kings 22:52; 2 Kings 10:29	Later kings walk in Jeroboam's way
2 Kings 17:21–23	His sin named as the root of the north's fall
2 Kings 23:15–18	Josiah tears down the Bethel altar (1 Kings 13:2)
Hosea 8:5–6; Amos 7:10–13	Prophets condemn the calf and Bethel
Echo: Exodus 32:1–8	Aaron's golden calf at Sinai

New Testament

Echo: Acts 7:39–41	Israel "rejoiced in the works of their own hands"
Echo: John 4:19–24	Worship "in spirit and in truth"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reasons did Jeroboam give himself for making the calves (1 Kings 12:26–28)?
2. *Understand:* God promised Jeroboam "a sure house" if he obeyed (1 Kings 11:38). Why did he not trust it?
3. *Apply:* Jeroboam said going to Jerusalem was "too much." Where are you tempted to make faith more convenient?
4. *Apply:* Fear drove Jeroboam's biggest decision. What fear is shaping a choice in front of you, and what would trusting God look like?